

Tether

A Couples Gratitude Journal for Noticing Why

90 DAYS · WRITE APART, REVEAL TOGETHER

Skyler Rasmussen

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The prompts, weekly reflections, and structure in this journal are original work.

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This book is a journal, not therapy. It is not a substitute for professional help. If your relationship is in trouble, or if you are not safe, talk to someone qualified.

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*The line between two people is invisible until one of you walks to the
end of it.*

The Tether

A tether is the line that keeps two things joined when one of them drifts. It isn't decorative. You mostly don't see it. You notice it the day it isn't there.

Most of what holds two people together is like that. It isn't the anniversary dinner. It's that they know how you take your coffee and they made it that way this morning without being asked, and you drank it without looking up.

This journal is ninety days of looking up.

The idea behind it is simple enough to say in a sentence: you already know why you love this person, and you have almost certainly stopped saying it. Not out of coldness. Out of obviousness. The reasons became so familiar they went quiet, the way a tether does.

There is some evidence that saying them matters. In a set of studies published in 2012, people who felt more appreciated by their partners were more appreciative in return — and the more appreciative partners were also more responsive to what their partner needed, more committed, and more likely to still be there later. That is a correlation, not a promise. It doesn't say gratitude keeps people together. It says that in couples who last, this particular thing tends to be present.

Two other findings shaped how this book works.

In 2006, researchers asked one partner in each of eighty-six dating couples to write for twenty minutes a day, three days running, about their deepest thoughts and feelings about the relationship. A comparison group wrote about their daily activities. Three months later, the couples in the writing group were more likely to still be together. One study, eighty-six couples, twenty years ago. Not proof of anything. But it is the reason you write your side alone.

And in 2013, partners who expressed gratitude to each other in a laboratory task — out loud, to the person's face — showed better relationship quality six months on, and what predicted it was whether the listener felt *understood*. That is the reason you read it to them afterward.

So: write apart, then reveal. The two halves are doing different work.

Ninety days is long enough that you'll run out of the easy answers, which is the point. Around week three you'll have to actually look at them.

How to Use This Journal

Every day has two facing pages and one question.

The left page is One. The right page is Two. Decide now who is which, write it on the next page, and keep it for the whole book. Your handwriting stays on one side the entire ninety days.

Answer your own side. Then stop.

Cover your side with your hand if you have to. It matters that you don't read theirs first.

If you read their answer before you write yours, you'll write toward it — agreeing, adding, softening. That's a fine conversation and it isn't this one. Write what you actually saw. Then turn the book around.

The reveal is the point. You'll find out what they noticed that you missed entirely.

Read them out loud. Not silently, sitting next to each other. Out loud, to their face. This takes eleven seconds and it is the part most people skip. It's also the part with the research behind it.

Three minutes each. Some nights it'll be two lines. That counts.

At the end of every week there's a page called The Weekly Tether. That one you do together, out loud, both of you at once. Nothing to hide there.

There are no dates in this book. Start on a Tuesday in March. Miss four days and pick it up again. A skipped page is a skipped page, not a failure — the only way to do this wrong is to stop.

Before You Begin

ONE IS

TWO IS

WE STARTED

*Write down one thing you each want out of the next ninety days. One sentence.
Come back and read it on day ninety.*

ONE

TWO

WEEK 1

Noticing the Ordinary

Love mostly happens in the small print. This week, slow down enough to read it.

What is one small thing they did today that you almost didn't notice — but did?

What is one small thing they did today that you almost didn't notice — but did?

Describe the exact sound of their laugh from this week. What set it off?

Describe the exact sound of their laugh from this week. What set it off?

When did you catch them being kind to someone who wasn't watching?

When did you catch them being kind to someone who wasn't watching?

What ordinary moment today would you be sad to lose?

What ordinary moment today would you be sad to lose?

Name a gesture of theirs so familiar you've stopped seeing it.
Look again — what does it mean?

Name a gesture of theirs so familiar you've stopped seeing it.
Look again — what does it mean?

What did their face do the last time they were genuinely surprised?

What did their face do the last time they were genuinely surprised?

Where were you standing the last time you thought, "I'm lucky"?

Where were you standing the last time you thought, "I'm lucky"?

THE WEEKLY TETHER

Read this week aloud to each other. What did your partner notice that you missed entirely?

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 2

Small Kindnesses

The big gestures get remembered. This week, count the ones that don't.

Name three tiny ways they took care of you this week.

Name three tiny ways they took care of you this week.

What did they hand you — literally or otherwise — before you had to ask?

What did they hand you — literally or otherwise — before you had to ask?

When did they make something easier for you without making a point of it?

When did they make something easier for you without making a point of it?

What comfort do they offer that you've quietly come to rely on?

What comfort do they offer that you've quietly come to rely on?

Describe a time they put your rest above their own convenience.

Describe a time they put your rest above their own convenience.

What did they remember that you had forgotten?

What did they remember that you had forgotten?

When did they choose your comfort over their own?

When did they choose your comfort over their own?

Which small kindness surprised you to be seen? Tell them so.

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 3

Words & Voice

Some sentences we carry for years. This week, notice the ones worth keeping.

What is a sentence they've said to you that you've never forgotten?

What is a sentence they've said to you that you've never forgotten?

When did their words land exactly when you needed them?

When did their words land exactly when you needed them?

What do they call you that no one else does — and how does it feel?

What do they call you that no one else does — and how does it feel?

Recall a time their honesty was a gift, even when it was hard to hear.

Recall a time their honesty was a gift, even when it was hard to hear.

What did they say the last time you doubted yourself?

What did they say the last time you doubted yourself?

When were you grateful they stayed quiet instead of filling the silence?

When were you grateful they stayed quiet instead of filling the silence?

What's a story they tell that you never tire of hearing?

What's a story they tell that you never tire of hearing?

THE WEEKLY TETHER

Say back to each other the words that mattered most this week.

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 4

Presence & Nearness

Being loved often just means being accompanied. This week, notice the company.

When did they show up — really show up — this week?

When did they show up — really show up — this week?

Describe the last time their presence made a hard thing bearable.

Describe the last time their presence made a hard thing bearable.

What does it feel like the moment they reach for your hand?

What does it feel like the moment they reach for your hand?

When did you feel most at home beside them recently?

When did you feel most at home beside them recently?

What has their attention taught you about being loved?

What has their attention taught you about being loved?

Recall a moment you were simply quiet together. What did it hold?

Recall a moment you were simply quiet together. What did it hold?

When did their being near you change how the whole day felt?

When did their being near you change how the whole day felt?

THE WEEKLY TETHER

Sit close and finish this together: "This week, being near you felt like..."

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 5

Choosing Gently

The point was never to win. This week, notice who chose the two of you.

When did one of you choose kindness over being right this week?

When did one of you choose kindness over being right this week?

What did they forgive you for before you'd finished apologizing?

What did they forgive you for before you'd finished apologizing?

Describe a disagreement that ended closer than it began.

Describe a disagreement that ended closer than it began.

When did they give you the benefit of the doubt?

When did they give you the benefit of the doubt?

What did they let go of for the sake of the two of you?

What did they let go of for the sake of the two of you?

When did you feel them choose the relationship over the argument?

When did you feel them choose the relationship over the argument?

What repair are you grateful they reached for first?

What repair are you grateful they reached for first?

THE WEEKLY TETHER

Name one thing you'll each choose to let go of, starting now.

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 6

Our Story

You are a history no one else has lived. This week, turn a few pages back.

What early moment between you do you keep returning to?

What early moment between you do you keep returning to?

When did you first know? Tell it the way you'd tell a stranger.

When did you first know? Tell it the way you'd tell a stranger.

What has this person survived that makes you proud to stand beside them?

Name a season you got through together that you couldn't have alone.

Name a season you got through together that you couldn't have alone.

What tradition — however small — belongs only to the two of you?

What tradition — however small — belongs only to the two of you?

How have they changed you in a way you're grateful for?

How have they changed you in a way you're grateful for?

What do you know now about love that you learned from them?

What do you know now about love that you learned from them?

THE WEEKLY TETHER

Tell one story from your history the other didn't know you'd kept.

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 7

The Work of a Shared Life

*A life together is held up by a thousand dull, faithful acts. This week,
name them.*

What did they carry this week so you didn't have to?

What did they carry this week so you didn't have to?

Name a thankless task they did that quietly held your life together.

Name a thankless task they did that quietly held your life together.

When did they handle something you were dreading?

When did they handle something you were dreading?

What part of your shared load do they shoulder without keeping score?

What part of your shared load do they shoulder without keeping score?

Describe the last time "I'll take care of it" meant everything.

Describe the last time "I'll take care of it" meant everything.

What did they fix, clean, or manage that you'd have left undone?

What did they fix, clean, or manage that you'd have left undone?

When did their reliability feel like tenderness?

When did their reliability feel like tenderness?

Thank each other, specifically, for one invisible thing.

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 8

Play & Laughter

Joy is not the opposite of serious love. This week, notice the fun.

What made you both laugh until it hurt recently?

What made you both laugh until it hurt recently?

What inside joke still works no matter the mood?

What inside joke still works no matter the mood?

When did they turn an ordinary evening into something fun?

When did they turn an ordinary evening into something fun?

What do you do together that makes you feel like kids again?

What do you do together that makes you feel like kids again?

Recall the last time they were gloriously, unselfconsciously silly.

Recall the last time they were gloriously, unselfconsciously silly.

What ritual is only funny because it's the two of you?

What ritual is only funny because it's the two of you?

When did their playfulness pull you out of a bad mood?

When did their playfulness pull you out of a bad mood?

THE WEEKLY TETHER

Plan one deliberately silly thing to do before next week.

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 9

Growth & Change

You are each still becoming. This week, notice who they're turning into.

What are they working on right now that you admire?

What are they working on right now that you admire?

How have they grown in the time you've known them?

How have they grown in the time you've known them?

When did you watch them do something brave this year?

When did you watch them do something brave this year?

What dream of theirs do you want to help come true?

What dream of theirs do you want to help come true?

Name a fear they've faced that you were proud to witness.

Name a fear they've faced that you were proud to witness.

What have they taught themselves that impresses you?

What have they taught themselves that impresses you?

Where do you see them going — and how do you want to walk alongside?

Where do you see them going — and how do you want to walk alongside?

Tell your partner one way you want to support their growth.

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 10

Repair & Forgiveness

Lasting love is mostly mending. This week, notice the grace between you.

What do you need to thank them for that you never said out loud?

What do you need to thank them for that you never said out loud?

When did they make room for your worst day?

When did they make room for your worst day?

What grace have they extended you more than once?

What grace have they extended you more than once?

Describe a wound the two of you healed together.

Describe a wound the two of you healed together.

When did "I'm sorry" from them change everything?

When did "I'm sorry" from them change everything?

What do you want to forgive — in them, or in yourself — today?

What do you want to forgive — in them, or in yourself — today?

When did they love you at your least lovable?

When did they love you at your least lovable?

Offer one honest repair, and receive theirs without defending.

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 11

Admiration & Desire

You get to want the person you love. This week, say so.

What do you find beautiful about them that has nothing to do with looks?

What do you find beautiful about them that has nothing to do with looks?

When did you feel a rush of wanting them recently — and why?

When did you feel a rush of wanting them recently — and why?

What strength of theirs do you quietly rely on?

What strength of theirs do you quietly rely on?

Finish this: "I still can't believe I get to..."

Finish this: "I still can't believe I get to..."

What about them turns your head after all this time?

What about them turns your head after all this time?

When were you proud to be seen as theirs?

When were you proud to be seen as theirs?

What would you fall for all over again?

What would you fall for all over again?

Say out loud one thing you desire or admire — no hedging.

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 12

Gratitude Outward

Love spills. This week, notice what the two of you give the world.

Who is better off because the two of you love each other?

Who is better off because the two of you love each other?

When did you two show kindness to someone else this week?

When did you two show kindness to someone else this week?

What do you build together that's bigger than the two of you?

What do you build together that's bigger than the two of you?

Who taught you something about love that you now practice together?

Who taught you something about love that you now practice together?

What are you grateful your relationship makes possible?

What are you grateful your relationship makes possible?

When did being a team let you give something you couldn't give alone?

When did being a team let you give something you couldn't give alone?

What do you hope people feel when they're in your home?

What do you hope people feel when they're in your home?

THE WEEKLY TETHER

Decide on one act of kindness to do together this week.

Do this one together, out loud.

WEEK 13

The Tether Ahead

You've spent ninety days learning to notice. This week, aim it forward.

What are you most looking forward to doing together?

What are you most looking forward to doing together?

Name what you want more of in the next ninety days.

Name what you want more of in the next ninety days.

What promise do you want to make — quietly — starting today?

What promise do you want to make — quietly — starting today?

These pages taught you to notice something. Say what.

These pages taught you to notice something. Say what.

What will you keep doing, now that you've seen how it feels?

What will you keep doing, now that you've seen how it feels?

Write the thing you most want them to know, and mean every word.

Write the thing you most want them to know, and mean every word.

Read the whole journal back to each other. What has changed
in how you see the two of you?

Do this one together, out loud.

Keep Noticing

You're at the end of a book, which is a strange place to be told the book wasn't the point.

Ninety days ago you probably thought this would be about being more grateful. It was about being more accurate. Gratitude is easy and vague. *There, that, that is why* — that's specific, and specific is harder, and specific is what they actually wanted to hear.

So here is the whole thing, now that you've practiced it:

Notice one true thing. Say it to them out loud.

That's it. That's what the ninety pages were for.

You don't need a book for that, which is good, because you've run out of one. Some couples buy a second copy and start again with different answers. Some keep a note on their phone. Some just get in the habit of turning toward the other person in the kitchen and saying the thing instead of letting it go by.

What you shouldn't do is put this on a shelf and go back to assuming they know.

They know. They just haven't heard it since Tuesday.

A Keepsake

Look back at day one. At what you wrote, and at what they wrote, and at how differently the two of you saw the same week.

That's the part worth keeping. Not the good handwriting days — the ones where you noticed something they didn't know you'd seen.

This journal grew out of Tether, a shared journal for two at *tether.skdaddle.com*, which works the same way: you write alone, and when both of you have answered, the words unlock side by side. Same idea, different object. If you want to keep going after this book, or you're in two different cities and can't share a page, that's where it lives.

But the paper version has one thing the app doesn't. In twenty years someone will open this and see your actual handwriting on the left and theirs on the right, and know exactly what the two of you were paying attention to in the spring of whatever year this was.

Put it somewhere you'll find it again.

Imprint

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